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Name of Author:

Ngugi & Ngũĩ wa Thiong'o

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4 *Imperialism of Language*

English, a Language for the World?

Everyone in the world has a language, either the language of his or her parents or one adopted at birth or at a later stage in life. So when we consider English as a possible language for the world, we are all drawing from the languages and cultures in which we are rooted. The topic also brings up the question of choosing one language from among many languages. What we are therefore discussing is the relationship between English and the various languages of the world. In short, we are really talking about the meeting of languages.

Every language has two aspects. One aspect is its role as an agent that enables us to communicate with one another in our struggle to find the means for survival. The other is its role as a carrier of the history and the culture built into the process of that communication over time. In my book *Decolonising the Mind* I have described language as the collective memory bank of a people. The two aspects are inseparable; they form a dialectical unity.

However, either of these two aspects can become more pronounced than the other, depending in the circumstances surrounding the use of a language, and particularly those surrounding an encounter between languages. For instance, are the two languages meeting on terms of equality and independence? The quality of the encounter between languages both in the past and in the world today, and hence the dominance of one aspect over the other at a given time, has been determined by the presence or absence of independence and quality between the nations involved.

Let me give one or two examples. Scandinavians know English. But they do not learn English in order for it to become the means of

communication among themselves in their own countries, or for it to become the carrier of their own national cultures, or for it to become the means by which foreign culture is imposed on them. They learn English to help them in their interactions with English people, or with speakers of English, to facilitate commerce, trade, tourism, and other links with foreign nations. For them English is only a means of communication with the outside world. The Japanese, the West Germans, and a good number of other peoples fall in the same category as the Scandinavians: English is not a substitute for their own languages.

When nations meet on terms of independence and equality, they tend to stress the need for communication in the language of the other. They choose the language of the other merely to ease communication in their dealings with one another. But when they meet as oppressor and oppressed, as for instance under imperialism, then their languages cannot experience a genuinely democratic encounter. The oppressor nation uses language as a means of entrenching itself in the oppressed nation. The weapon of language is added to that of the Bible and the sword in pursuit of what David Livingstone, in the case of nineteenth-century imperialism, called 'Christianity plus 5 percent.' Today he would have probably described the same process as Christianity, debt, plus 40 percent in debt servicing. In such a situation, what is at stake is language as more than a simple means of communication.

Needless to say, the encounter between English and most so-called Third World languages did not occur under conditions of independence and equality. English, French, and Portuguese came to the Third World to announce the arrival of the Bible and the sword. They came clamouring for gold, black gold in chains, or gold that shines as sweat in factories and plantations. If it was the gun which made possible the mining of this gold and which effected the political captivity of their owners, it was language which held captive their cultures, their values, and hence their minds. The latter was attempted in two ways, both of which are part of the same process.

The first was to suppress the languages of the captive nations. The culture and the history carried by these languages were thereby thrown onto the rubbish heap and left there to perish. These languages were experienced as incomprehensible noise from the dark

Tower of Babel. In the secondary school that I went to in Kenya, one of the hymns we were taught to sing was a desperate cry for deliverance from that darkness. Every morning, after we paraded our physical cleanliness for inspection in front of the Union Jack, the whole school would troop down to the chapel to sing: 'Lead kindly light amidst the encircling gloom, lead thou me on.' Our languages were part of that gloom. Our languages were suppressed so that we, the captives, would not have our own mirrors in which to observe ourselves and our enemies.

The second mode of captivation was that of elevating the language of the conquerer. It became the language of the elect. Those inducted into the school system, after having been sifted from the masses of the people, were furnished with new mirrors in which to see themselves and their people as well as those who had provided the new mirrors. In short, they were given a language called English or French or Portuguese. Thus equipped with the linguistic means of escape from the dark Tower of Babel, the newly ordained, or those ready to be ordained as servants of the new order, had their minds systematically removed from the world and the history carried by their original languages. They looked, or were made to look, to a distant neon light on a faraway hill flashing out the word EUROPE. Henceforth Europe and its languages would be the centre of the universe.

The French, faithful to the philosophical and aesthetic traditions of their culture, had given the whole process a name: *assimilation*. The English, less aesthetically and philosophically inclined, simply called it *education*. But Lugard, a soldier-turned-administrator who nonetheless retained the bluntness of a military man, had provided the key to understanding what lay behind this pragmatic education programme, one that was often formulated in bits and pieces: *indirect rule*. He had coined the phrase to refer to the practice of co-opting chiefs to facilitate British rule in Africa. In fact, subsequent educational practice produced more faithful 'chiefs' for the system as a whole than those who had been appointed earlier by Lugard. The point however is that the mastery of the English language was the measure of one's readiness for election into the band of the elect.

In *Decolonising the Mind* I have described how the process of alienation from our own languages with the acquisition of a new one

actually worked. I have told of instances of children being punished if they were caught speaking their African languages. We were often caned or made to carry plaques inscribed with the words 'I am stupid' or 'I am an ass'. In some cases, our mouths were stuffed with pieces of paper picked from the wastepaper basket, which were then passed from one mouth to that of the latest offender. Humiliation in relation to our languages was the key. 'Look up unto the hills' was the constant call: that was where the light from Europe shone, and the gateway to it was English. The English language was the bearer of all knowledge in the arts and sciences. According to Greek tradition, Archimedes could have moved the world had he had a firm ground on which to stand. In twentieth-century Africa he would have been advised to stand on the firm ground of the English language in order to move the world. Indeed for some of us, English was made to look as if it was the language spoken by God.

One of our English teachers, ironically a Scotsman, used to urge us to follow the footsteps of Christ in the use of the English language. As you know, when young people learn a new language, they tend to favour the heaviest and longest of words because such words sound more learned. The teacher would tell us that Jesus Christ used the simplest English. The Bible contained the greatest sentence in English literature which happened also to be the shortest. It was left to a student to remind him that Jesus probably spoke Hebrew, and that the Bible from which the King James Version had been translated, was more likely to have been written in Hebrew.*

You may think that I am talking about some attitudes to the English language that prevailed thirty years ago. Well, you are very wrong. Recently, on my way to Berlin with my mind very much on this seminar, I chanced to open the London *Evening Standard* of 7 October 1988, and came across an article concerning the British education secretary Kenneth Baker's visit to the Soviet Union. The paper told us how Baker had been amazed to find English being spoken in a certain part of the Soviet Union: 'Just think of it. There I was in Novosibirsk. Two thousand miles from anywhere, and yet the people could speak English perfectly. They've never been to England or America. But they read our classics.' That is well and

*I note that Christ spoke Aramaic and not Hebrew and that the New Testament was written in Greek. To correct the child's misconception is hardly to weaken his point, which retains its polemical truth with respect to the teacher's assumptions.

good. Any group learning the language of another group is a positive thing. But why were these citizens of Novosibirsk putting so much work into perfecting their English? According to Kenneth Baker, as quoted by the same issue of the *Standard*, there was a deeper motive: 'The Russians associate England with progress, so they work thoroughly and very hard at their English. They want to get away from the old-fashioned totalitarian state-controlled society.' You have heard it for yourselves. Socialism, which is only seventy years old, is already old-fashioned. Capitalism, which is four hundred years old, is modern. But the point to note for our argument is that even today English is the means of taking people away from the 'gloom' of socialism into the 'light' of modern capitalism.

Let me now relate to you very briefly how some of us were taken by English from the dark Babelic towers of nineteenth-century Africa to the modernity of twentieth-century colonial Africa. In my primary school we were taught English from a text under the general series 'Oxford Readers for Africa'. We used to read the story of a boy called John and a girl called Joan. And it thus came to pass that, while still in my village and before I knew the names of any other towns in Kenya, I already knew about a town called Oxford where the two children were born and another called Reading, where John and Joan went to school. We, the new readers, followed them wherever they went. One day we went to visit another town called London; we went to a zoo and walked along the banks of the river Thames. It was a summer holiday. Oh, how many times did the river Thames and the British Houses of Parliament beckon to us from the pages of our English language text books! Even today, when I hear the name of the river Thames or travel in its vicinity, I still remember Joan and John. And Oxford represents to me less the great seat of exclusive scholarship that it is supposed to be than the exclusive home of the fictitious John and Joan of my primary school textbook.

Don't get me wrong. I do not think it a bad thing for a language to be taught in the geographical, cultural, or historical setting of the land which produces it. After all, even the communicative aspect of a language cannot be divorced from its cultural emblems – the Thames for the English language, the Eiffel Tower for the French, the Leaning Tower of Pisa for the Italian, the Great Wall of China

for the Chinese, Mecca for the Arabic, Mombasa for the Kiswahili. To know a language in the context of its culture is a tribute to the people to whom it belongs, and that is good. What has, for us from the former colonies, twisted the natural relation to languages, both our own and those of other peoples, is that the languages of Europe – here, English – were taught as if they were our own languages, as if Africa had no tongues except those brought there by imperialism, bearing the label **MADE IN EUROPE**.

Thus English and the African languages never met as equals, under conditions of equality, independence, and democracy, and this is the root of all subsequent distortions. They met with English as the language of the conquering nation, and ours as the language of the vanquished. An oppressor language inevitably carries racist and negative images of the conquered nation, particularly in its literature, and English is no exception. I do not want to go into this aspect of the language here. Many studies in this area have already been done. Suffice it to say that some works bearing these offensive images, like those of Elspeth Huxley, Karen Blixen, Rider Haggard, Robert Ruark, Nicholas Monsarrat, to name just a few, found their way into the school English curriculum. Imagine it: if the African languages had all died, African people would have had to define themselves in a language that had such a negative conception of Africa as its legacy.

What prevented our languages from being completely swallowed up by English and other oppressor languages was that the rural and urban masses, who had refused to surrender completely in the political and economic spheres, also continued to breathe life into our languages and thus helped to keep alive the histories and cultures they carried. The masses of Africa would often derive the strength needed in their economic and political struggles from those very languages. Thus the peoples of the Third World had refused to surrender their souls to English, French, or Portuguese.

But the Third World was not the only place where English tried to grow on the graveyard of other peoples' languages. Even in Britain I have heard similar complaints from regions whose original languages had been swallowed up by English or in regions where they are putting up a last ditch struggle to prevent their languages from being killed and buried forever.

Once again, I am not only talking about complaints that I heard

many years ago. When I returned from West Berlin, I happened to open a newspaper, the *Morning Star* of 21 October 1988, only to find an article by Lyn Marierid of the Welsh Language Society protesting the continuing decline of the Welsh language:

In recent years, rural areas, which have for decades been considered strongholds of the language, have become completely Anglicised as ordinary working-class people have been systematically priced out of their native areas.

Perhaps some readers are asking at this point why it should be so important to retain such a language as Welsh.

If we consider it important for a people to be aware of their past in order to be able to shape their future, then it is pointedly relevant. For generations, the Welsh working class was utterly dependent on the Welsh language and culture.

Now it appears that the Welsh language in Wales is under threat of death. That, indeed, is the cost of 'yuppification' in this particular part of Britain. Should it die, then the history of a whole people would be a closed book for many people.

As socialists we know that capitalist culture seeks to deny working people their rightful place in their own history so that it may not be a source of inspiration for their continued struggle in the present.

Language too is denied them for similar reasons.

Languages do not grow, age and die. They do not become irrelevant to the 'modern age' due to some intrinsic fault in their composition.

They are lost when the predominant class in society has no use for them.

The decline of the Welsh language has roots in the inequality prevailing between the nationalities that inhabited the two linguistic regions. Even Kenneth Baker, when talking about the spread of English in Russia, did not say, from what one gathers in reading the report in the *Evening Standard*, that the Soviets looked up to Britain for progress. They looked to England, the original home of the English language.

Today, the West European languages and African languages are where they are in relation to one another, not because they are

inherently progressive or backward but because of the history of oppression on one hand, and the resistance to that oppression on the other. That history of oppression dates back a long time, but it is best symbolised by the Berlin Conference of 1884 at which Africa, for example, was carved up into various 'spheres of influence' of the European powers. Today we can see that English, outside its home base in Britain and the United States, has firmly taken root in all respects only in those areas of the globe – and these are quite considerable – which have been within the Anglo-American economic and political empire stretching from Queen Victoria to Ronald Reagan. These are also the areas in which neo-colonialism has taken firm root. The rulers of these neo-colonies feel that they share the same outlook as the rulers of the United States and Britain because, quite apart from many other things they have in common, they speak the same tongue and share the value systems of the English-speaking ruling classes the world over.

The consequences of that history of inequality and oppression can be seen in each of the affected countries in Africa, particularly in the internal relations between the various classes and in the external relations with other countries. In these countries, English, French, and Portuguese occupy the centre stage. They are the official languages of instruction, of administration, of commerce, trade, justice, and foreign communications. In short, they are the languages of power. But they are still spoken only by a minority within each of the nationalities that make up these countries. The majority of the working people in Africa retain our African languages. Therefore the majority of the people are excluded from centre stage since they do not have mastery of the language of power. They are also excluded from any meaningful participation in modern discoveries. English, French, and Portuguese are the languages in which the African people have been educated; for this reason the results of our research into science, technology and of our achievements in the creative arts are stored in those languages. Thus a large portion of this vast knowledge is locked up in the linguistic prison of English, French, and Portuguese. Even the libraries are really English (or indeed French or Portuguese) language fortresses inaccessible to the majority. So the cultivation of these languages makes for more effective communication only between the elite and the international English-speaking bourgeoisie. In short the elite in Africa is,

in linguistic terms, completely uprooted from the peoples of Africa and tied to the West.

As for external relations between Africa and the world, African languages hardly occupy any place of honour. Once again their place has been occupied by English, French, or Portuguese. Among the official languages at the United Nations there is not a single language of African origin. In fact it is interesting that of the five continents, the only one not represented linguistically at the United Nations is Africa. It is surely time that Kiswahili, or Hausa, Wolof, Shona, Amharic, or Somali be made one of the official languages of the United Nations Organisation and all its organs; but that is a matter for another seminar. At present we are discussing English as a possible language for the world.

I have so far discussed or pointed out only the racist tradition of the English language. As a language of imperialism, it could not but be marked by the very disease it carried. But as the language of the people of Britain and America, it also has a democratic tradition, reflecting the democratic struggles and heritage of the British and American people. In its democratic tradition it has added to the common pool of human creativity; in the arts, for instance, with such great names as Shakespeare, Milton, Blake, Shelley, Dickens, Conrad, Bernard Shaw, Graham Greene, to name only a few. I am not surprised that Kenneth Baker found Soviet children in Siberia reading some of these classics of the English language. If he had also gone to even the remotest village in Africa he might very well have found more children struggling with Dickens, alongside Brecht, Balzac, Sholokhov, and of course Sembene Ousmane, Alex la Guma, Veiera, and other African writers. A lot of this material would be available in English translation. That side of the English language is important, and it is part of the common heritage of humankind along with what has been contributed by other languages, including those from Africa. But English as a language for the world is another matter.

English, a language for the world? It would certainly be good for each country in the world to have a language in which all nationalities inhabiting its boundaries could participate. It would be equally good if the world had a language in which all the nations of the earth could communicate. A common language of communication within a country, a common language of communication for the

world: that is the ideal, and we have to struggle for it.

But that language, whichever it would be, should not be planted in the graveyard of other languages within one country or in the world. We must avoid the destruction that English has wrought on other languages and cultures in its march to the position it now occupies in the world. The death of many languages should never be the condition for the life of a few. On the contrary, the lives of many languages should add life to whichever language emerges as the transnational or universal language of communication between people. We, the present generation, must distance ourselves from the false and bloody logic of development theory handed to us by imperialism: the claim that the cleanliness of one person must depend on pouring dirt onto others; that the health of a few must depend on their passing their leprosy onto others; that the wealth of a few people or a few nations must be rooted in the poverty of the masses of people and nations.

So, what would be the proper foundation for the emergence and the universal acceptance of a language for the world?

First, the absolute independence and equality of all nations in the economic, political, and cultural spheres. Such an equality would of course be reflected in the equality of languages. We live in one world. All the languages in the world are real products of human history.

They are our common heritage. A world of many languages should be like a field of flowers of different colours. There is no flower which becomes more of a flower on account of its colour or its shape. All such flowers express their common 'floralness' in their diverse colours and shapes. In the same way our different languages can, should, and must express our common being. So we should let all our languages sing of the unity of the people of the earth, of our common humanity, and above all of the people's love for peace, equality, independence, and social justice. All our languages should join in the demand for a new international economic, political, and cultural order.

Then the different languages should be encouraged to talk to one another through the medium of interpretation and translation. Each country should encourage the teaching of languages from the five continents of the earth. There is no reason why each child should not master at least three languages as a matter of course. The

art of translation and interpretation should be an integral subject in schools, but it is sad to note that in the English education system and in English culture generally, the art of translation does not enjoy the same status as the other arts. Through translations, the different languages of the world can speak to one another. European languages have always communicated with one another such that today it is possible to read nearly all the classics of Russian, French, or German literature and philosophy in any of those languages, thanks to the art of translation. But there is very little mutual translation between African languages and, say, English and French. And the colonial dominance of English and French in African lives has made African languages so suspicious of one another that there is hardly any inter-African communication. In any case, very few resources, if any, nationally or internationally, have been put into the development of African languages. The best minds among lettered Africans have been channelled into the developing of English, French, and Portuguese. But, difficult as the case may be, interlanguage communication through translation is crucial. If on top of all of this there were one common language, then the different languages of the world could further communicate with one another via the international common language. In that way, we could build a real foundation for a common world culture that is firmly rooted in, and draws its real sustenance from, all the peoples of the world with their distinct experiences and languages. Our internationalism would be truly rooted in all the peoples of the world.

When there is real economic, political, and cultural equality among nations and there is *democracy*, there will be no reason for any nation, nationality, or people to fear the emergence of a common language, be it Kiswahili, Chinese, Maori, Spanish, or English, as the language of the world. A language for the world? A world of languages! The two concepts are not mutually exclusive provided there is independence, equality, democracy, and peace among nations.

In such a world, English, like all the other languages, can put in an application, and despite its history of imperialist aggression against other languages and peoples, English would make a credible candidate. Such applicants must in the meantime work hard to remove such negative qualities as racism, sexism, national chauvin-

ism, and negative images of other nationalities and races so as to meet the criteria of acceptance as a language for the world. In this respect Kiswahili would make an excellent candidate for the world language. It already has the advantage of never having grown in the graveyard of other languages. Kiswahili has created space for itself in Africa and the world without displaying any national chauvinism. The power of Kiswahili has not depended on its economic, political, or cultural aggrandisement. It has no history of oppression or domination of other cultures. And yet Kiswahili is now spoken as a major language in Eastern, Central, and Southern Africa as well as in many other parts of the world.

I have nothing against English, French, Portuguese, or any other language for that matter. They are all valid in as far as they are languages and in as far as they do not seek to oppress other nations, nationalities, and languages. But if Kiswahili or any other African language were to become the language for the world, this would symbolise the dawn of a new era in human relations between the nations and peoples of Africa and those of other continents. For these reasons I for one would like to propose Kiswahili as the language for the world.

Translated from the *Gikũyũ* by Wangũi wa Goro and Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o.